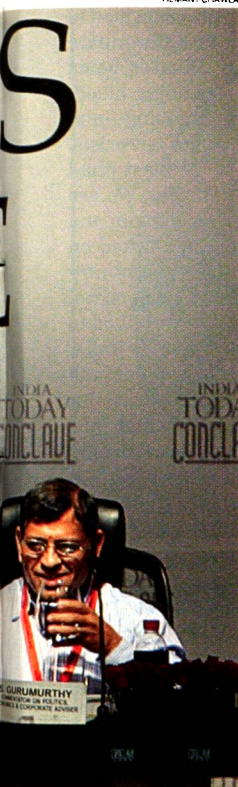


HEMANT CHAWLA



(FROM LEFT) MADANI,
SENIOR JOURNALIST
AND SESSION
CHAIRPERSON M.J.
AKBAR, MANJI AND
GURUMURTHY

humble view, dogma deserves to be threatened by questions. I take this distinction of faith versus dogma seriously. Another crucial distinction is education vs indoctrination. Education, in an open society like ours or here in India, gives you the permission to use your mind critically. Indoctrination, which is what you find in closed societies, squelches the permission to use your mind critically. By self-study, I came to understand so many of the positive dimensions of Islam, including the concept of independent thinking, debate and dissent. There is a desperate hunger among younger Muslims to engage in reinterpretation to make a humane and reasonable Islam in a pluralistic 21st century context. Just as terrorism takes inspiration from religious dogma, so the opposite of terror—individual liberty and dignity—can take strength from the better angels of the faith. We can choose hate, or we can choose love. We can choose fear, or we can choose freedom. We can choose dogma, or we can choose faith.

“There is certainly a religious angle to terror”

S. GURUMURTHY
POLITICAL COMMENTATOR

All religions are sacred for their respective followers. A religion which contravenes this principle has the potential for causing problems like the terror that we see today. It never distinguishes between the combatant and non-combatant. Human beings have violence stored in them in varying degrees in their DNA. That is why the religions, that is why the spiritual masters came up all over the world to restrain, contain and moderate this violent implication in man. And the question is whether a religion has a demonstrable capacity to restrain violence by individuals. When individuals collectivise themselves, it becomes collective violence. So religion, according to me, is definitely a restraining factor and whether religion performs this job depends upon the propensity of the religion, historicity of that religion and its basic principles and more important, its attitude towards other religions. If a religion has a proper attitude towards other religions, then there is no scope for clash. This is where, I think, the problem arises in respect of a monotheistic state because of their history, because of their holy book, because of

the basic principles, and because of the way in which they look at each other and other religions. There is a propensity to distinguish themselves so aggressively, so powerfully, so distinctly that there is a potentiality for clash between them, and between them and other religions. Terror has drawn its principles of attacking innocent people.

Today we are talking about what is broadly recognised as Islamic terror, and when I say Islamic terror, I mean nothing about Islam. Because Islam is a very sacred religion for the followers of Islam. We have to respect it, anyone who believes in a multi-religious society has to. We have to understand how terrorists have hijacked Islam on the principles which Islamic schools of thought are unable to dissolve. Terrorists in Gujarat, in Jaipur, in Delhi. It's very clear, Islam says, my text says, that “kafirs have to be eliminated and we have the right to eliminate you kafirs”. It's a religious document which they use not only to justify to kill, that is the document by which they have inspired and motivated themselves and are inspiring and motivating hundreds of others. The monotheistic faiths have classified themselves as the only true faith. Their God is the only true God, all other gods are false gods. Unless this issue whether Hindus are kafirs or not, whether non-believers of Islam are kafirs or not is clarified, the religious magnet which gathers a massive youth population to look up to the terrorists and to take to their ways can never be contained. Whether religion promotes terror or not because one religion doesn't interpret itself properly, that is the problem of Islam today.

“Terrorism is giving a bad name to religion”

MAULANA MAHMOOD MADANI
JAMIAT-UL-ULEMA-E-HIND GENERAL SECRETARY

The Dalai Lama made some valuable suggestions in the first session. If we follow them, it will mean a solution of 90 per cent of our current problems. Today's subject is: What is the role of religion? In fact, the greatest problem is terrorism, which is a fact. And terrorism is giving a bad name to it. Today's topic has changed from religion to Islam. But the crux of the problem is that terrorism is being used for political gains. People are using religion for political gains. Who has been maligned by this? Religion, or plainly speaking,